

MGT 410R: Competitive Strategy

Fall 2026

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DESCRIPTION

This course focuses on strategic decision making by companies in competitive markets. The approach will combine applied economic theory with empirical examples to develop competitive advantage and game theory frameworks. Classes will consist of lecture and discussion of applications, including case studies.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this course you will be able to:

- Identify sources of profit within and across industries
- Understand how to create and sustain a business' competitive advantage
- Direct how a company should grow, innovate and respond to changing markets
- Analyze strategic interactions between competing and complementary companies
- Shape the nature of industry competition to your advantage
- Use strategic frameworks to communicate within and across businesses

MATERIALS & LOGISTICS

Required Course Packet. The course packet contains the readings, case studies and articles for the course. It is available at the Study.net link through Canvas.

Canvas. All materials not included in the course packet will be posted on Canvas. This includes lecture slides and a practice exam. In addition, readings and assignments are subject to change. Please check Canvas regularly for updated materials.

Supplementary texts. The following texts are good resources for additional background on topics covered in the class. These are optional and not required.

Besanko, David, David Dranove, Mark Shanley and Scott Schaefer. *Economics of Strategy, Seventh Edition*. John Wiley & Sons, 2017. Referred to below as BDSS.

Dixit, Avinash K., and Barry Nalebuff. *The Art of Strategy: A Game Theorist's Guide To Success In Business & Life*. WW Norton & Company, 2008.

GRADING

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|-----------------------------------|-----|
| • Participation: | 20% |
| • Group case write-ups (5 total): | 20% |
| • Exam: | 30% |
| • Final group project: | 30% |

DELIVERABLES

Online and In-Class Participation

- The quality of your participation is essential for the class to work. This includes participation online and in the classroom.
- Your participation grade will include active participation during in-class discussions, thoughtful responses to online discussions, and grades on online quizzes.
- For many discussions, there will not be a “correct” answer; rather, we are looking for thoughtful responses that reflect your perspective and experiences.
- Online discussion posts can be brief. You will receive credit for quality and thoughtfulness, not quantity.
- You are responsible for the concepts and examples in the readings.

Please do your best to attend every class since active discussion is an important learning opportunity. In the event that you miss a class, you can make up participation points for one class by submitting your own mini-case: (1) Find a recent news article about a company/industry that relates to one of the topics in the missed lecture. (2) In (max) one page, explain the relevant question or decision the firm has to make and then describe how you would approach this using the tools from lecture.

Class participation also includes completing the course evaluation as well as a “Peer Evaluation Form” at the end of the quarter to evaluate the contributions of your group members. The evaluations will be kept confidential and will not be shared with other group members. The evaluations will be used to inform my assessment of individual contributions to group work and may be used to adjust individual grades on the group assignments.

Group Case Write-ups

Each study group will submit 5 case write-ups during the quarter.

- A brief response to write-up questions listed on canvas for each case.

- The write-up should be easy to read, tie in relevant theoretical material, and draw appropriate conclusions using the frameworks we discuss in class.
- You may use bullet points. Aim for 1-2 pages (double spaced, 12-point font and 1-inch margins). Do not include appendices, unless specifically mentioned in the case prompt. The motivation for short write-ups is to encourage you to think carefully about the most relevant information to include, rather than attempting to include all information.
- You may discuss the case with other students outside your group and use ChatGPT or other AI tools to help inform your analysis as you prepare your write-up. However, every student in the group is responsible for understanding the case, how the concepts from class have been applied, and how the group ultimately reached the conclusions in their write up.
- Upload write-ups to Canvas before the deadline. Points will be deducted for late write-ups. Write-ups submitted after case review videos are posted will not be accepted.

Take-home Exam

- The exam will consist of True/False/Uncertain, short answer and case questions.
- A practice exam with solutions will be provided.
- Do not consult any outside sources, AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT), or discuss the exam with anyone.

Group Final Strategy Project

The main project in the course is an analysis of a company to be completed with your team. You should think of the final project as a more in-depth and less directed version of the case write-up. The goal of the project is to have you practice the skills necessary to do competitive analysis on your own. Given that, the structure of the assignment is designed to match the structure of a competitive analysis you will do on the job.

The first step will be for you as a team to select a company and strategic problem they face. The three components of this project are:

- (1) a written Five Forces Industry Analysis
- (2) a written Positioning Analysis
- (3) Presentation of Problem and Recommendation of a Solution

The Presentation of Problem and Solution will take place on the last day of class and your team will present a key problem your client is facing and offer a solution to that problem. This presentation should include an executive summary slide and will also include the findings from your analyses where relevant. Each team member is encouraged to take a role in the final presentation. Additional guidelines, like presentation times, will be announced.

Part of your participation grade in the course will involve asking questions to the other groups when they present, so please be an active participant.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

How the Honor Code applies to this course:

- Do not solicit or receive materials from students who have taken the class.
- Do not discuss cases or assignments with anyone other than your study group.
- Do not discuss the exam with anyone including members of your study group.

AI Policy

Use of AI tools such as ChatGPT is permitted in this class for the purposes of enhancing learning. However, it is the responsibility of each student to ensure that their use of AI tools does not constitute academic misconduct, such as plagiarism or cheating.

In preparing for assignments, AI tools may be used to supplement your own reading of the case and lecture materials. However, graded work should reflect your own analysis; AI can support process, not replace thinking. The use of AI tools is not permitted for the exam.

Students are expected to use AI tools in a responsible and ethical manner and to abide by the guidelines set forth by the instructor. Any violation of these guidelines will result in disciplinary action.

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

Week	Modality	Topics
Week 0	Online	Course introduction Review WTP and elasticity
Week 1	Online	Five forces Enterprise mini-case
Week 2	Online & in person	Competitive advantage Cola wars case
Week 3	Online	Growth Ikea mini-case Disney case
Week 4	Online	Market entry Ryanair case
Week 5	Online	Price competition
Week 6	Online & in person	Networks Peer feedback on draft final project
Week 7	Online	Exam
Week 8	Online	Experiments in firms Stitch Fix case
Week 9	Online	Global strategy Coffee wars case
Week 10	In person	Final project presentations Class summary